

Gastornis

gas-TORE-niss



- **When** 55–45 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe and N. America
- **Habitat** Tropical and subtropical forests
- **Length** Over 6½ ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Unknown

Discovered in France in 1855, *Gastornis* was named after Gaston Plante, the scientist who found it. A similar bird called *Diatryma* was later found in North America and is now thought to be the same creature. *Gastornis* had large, powerful legs but didn't have the athletic build of a fast runner. Perhaps it was an ambush hunter, hiding in dense forest and waiting for small animals to wander close, before stamping them to death with its giant feet or snatching them in its beak. Some experts think it was a plant-eater and used its beak to crush tough leaves. Others think it was a scavenger that fed on corpses.

▲ MONSTROUS BEAK

Gastornis's huge beak had a slightly hooked tip, like that of a bird of prey. According to some scientists, its bite was strong enough to crack open coconuts and bones. Males and females had similar beaks, so the large size probably didn't evolve for attraction.

Tiny, useless wing



Name game

For more than 100 years, scientists thought *Diatryma* from America and *Gastornis* from Europe were totally different. But then someone realized that the *Gastornis* fossils had been put together incorrectly and they were actually the same bird. Now both are known as *Gastornis*, the older name.

